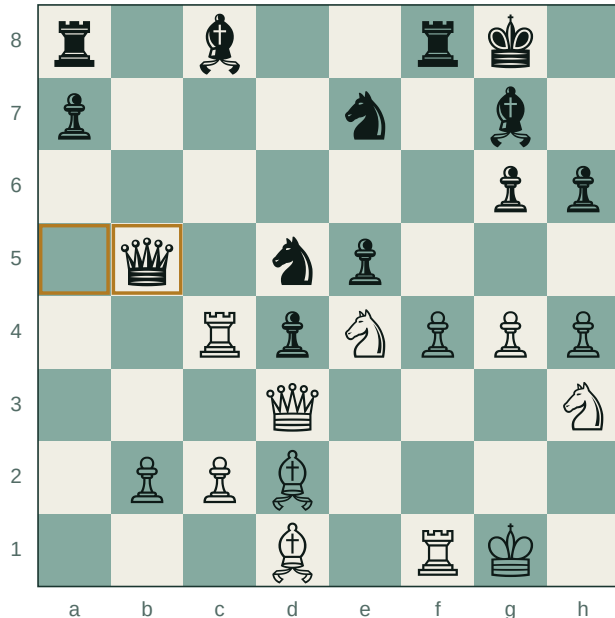


Exposed-king tactics: White, move 23

Exposed-king tactics

White to move



Previous move: 22...Qb5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

23. Rxc8 Qxd3 24. Rxf8+ Rxf8 25. cxd3

23.Rxc8 The rook captures the bishop on c8. From c8 it attacks rook on f8 and rook on a8. Recorded reply: **23...Qxd3**.

24.Rxf8+ Check restricts Black to 4 legal replies here. From f8 it attacks king on g8 and rook on a8. Recorded reply: **24...Rxf8**.

25.cxd3 The pawn captures the queen on d3.

At the end, nominal material is White 22 / Black 19 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from +0 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A king without pawns is not automatically mated. Count active attackers and examine escapes toward friendly pieces.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An exposed king gives the attacker checks and access to nearby squares. Coordinate pieces so the checks drive it into a worse net rather than toward safety.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect open files, diagonals, and unprotected squares around the king. Calculate checks in an order that preserves the attack.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: rook on a8 and queen on b5. Check for tactical protection.